Costa’s moment of truth

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CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back with you, wishing a happy European Council Day to all who celebrate. I’ll be spending the first part of mine recovering from Brussels Oktoberfest — full dispatch below.

In today’s Playbook:

— Everything you need to know ahead of a marathon diplomatic session.

— The AfD’s European party is promising reforms — but denies breaching EU values.

— Faces in the crowd: Maroš Šefčovič, Andrej Babiš, Roberta Metsola, Thierry Baudet, Pedro Sánchez, Günther Oettinger, Marine Le Pen, Andrius Kubilius, Giorgia Meloni and more ...

On today’s Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Sarah discuss why Europe’s defense commissioner sounds so much like Washington when he talks about EU security.

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DRIVING THE DAY

COSTA'S BIG TEST: Nearly two years into the job, European Council chief António Costa will today face the biggest test of his presidency yet, Gregorio Sorgi reports.

Taking over negotiations between squabbling governments on the EU's next seven-year budget at today's leaders' summit in Brussels, Costa is determined to secure a deal by the end of the year. That would not only avoid the messiness of all the high-profile national elections next year — it would also enable him to show off a clear victory before potentially securing a second term.

"It's impossible to have a new budget [from] Jan. 1, 2028, if you don't approve this budget by the end of this year," Costa told reporters yesterday. Failure to reach a deal would lead to an investment shortfall and stymie Europe's capacity to defend itself, he said.

If only it were that easy ⋯ At a private meeting recently, officials could barely conceal their laughter when told that an end-of-year budget deal was possible, according to a senior EU diplomat who was granted anonymity to speak frankly about the fraught conversations.

Messy domestic politics is getting in the way of Costa's plan. Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni, who is running for re-election and under pressure from angry regions and farmers, told MPs on Wednesday that "we will sign an agreement only when it is right for Italy."

Ominously for Costa's ambitions — and for today's summit — Italy, France and others have already watered down a commitment to secure a deal by the end of the year, according to draft conclusions for the meeting seen by Playbook .

Berlin and Paris are key to resolving the deadlock, but Friedrich Merz and Emmanuel Macron are hamstrung by weak political positions at home , as my colleagues Nick Vinocur, Giorgio Leali and Clea Caulcutt report. (The front-runner to succeed Macron, far-right leader Marine Le Pen, piled on the pressure in Brussels last night, telling reporters that the attempt to speed up the budget talks is a "democratic scandal.")

Costa's timeline is also imperiled by an election in Spain on Nov. 29, which polls suggest Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez is on track to lose. The Spanish vote adds uncertainty to a special EU summit on the budget that is provisionally scheduled for Nov. 26. "It will probably take place," a senior EU official said. "We will have to then see what will be on the table."

So what could delays mean? From today, leaders will start knocking on Costa's door to save their pet projects. "The more time passes, the more it plays into the hands of those pushing for cuts," said a senior EU diplomat.

Today's discussion will signal how far leaders are from a landing zone — especially on the tricky issue of EU-wide taxes, known as own resources, to finance the budget.

The toughest fight will be over the figures presented by Ireland, which has steered the talks over the past four months under its rotating presidency of the Council of the EU. Dublin has floated major reductions to the European Commission's budget proposal.

FOLLOW THE ACTION TODAY: Our team at the summit will keep you updated through the day in our live blog .

BIG AND BREAKING

FICO OPENS THE DOOR: Slovakia is reviving a dormant cooperation forum with Moscow after five years, with Russian oil, gas, nuclear fuel and even the treatment of athletes on the agenda. Zoya Sheftalovich and Max Griera have the exclusive.

A NEW RUSSIA TWIST: Donald Trump's special envoys proposed that European countries unfreeze Russian assets and transfer them to a vehicle overseen by Washington in an attempt to revive peace talks with Moscow, the FT reports . European delegates shot down the idea.

SATELLITE SQUEEZE: Ukrainian officers say the reported restrictions to Elon Musk's Starlink service are "comparable to a nuclear strike against us," with severe consequences for Kyiv's military operations, my colleagues report .

CASH CRUNCH AT FRONTEX: The EU border agency has suspended applications for its program to help deported migrants reintegrate after burning through its budget , Eliza Gkritsi and Hanne Cokelaere scooped.

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ESN FIGHTS FOR SURVIVAL

EXCLUSIVE — AfD'S PARTY PLEDGES REFORMS TO DODGE A BAN: The far-right Europe of Sovereign Nations, the EU party whose members include Alternative for Germany, rejected claims by the EU's party watchdog that it breached the bloc's values — but promised new internal rules to keep its national parties in line, according to a 160-page defense obtained by POLITICO.

ESN argued that many of the breaches alleged by the Authority for European Political Parties and Foundations predate the party and can't be attributed to it, and that investigators rely too heavily on subjective interpretations of what constitutes a breach of EU values, Max Griera reports. The defense said deregistration would be disproportionate and proposed lesser sanctions, including a "reprimand" or "temporary suspension of funding."

The party said it amended its statutes this summer after the allegations surfaced, creating an ethics committee to monitor compliance with EU values, investigate internal breaches, recommend corrective measures and produce an annual report. It also drafted a code of conduct to guide its member parties on respecting EU values.

Russia defense: The watchdog's case cited Dutch Forum for Democracy leader Thierry Baudet's praise of Vladimir Putin and Bulgarian party Revival's pact with United Russia as examples of breaches of EU values. ESN said Baudet was criticizing NATO and Western foreign policy, not directly endorsing Russia's war.

“One may reject that view, but it should not be regarded as a violation of EU values,” the defense said. It called Revival’s pact “merely a symbolic declaration intended to promote dialogue and normalization,” and argued that without financial or material support, it breached no EU sanctions.

Historically, the watchdog has favored fixes over punishment. Between 2022 and 2025, the APPF identified 30 breaches of spending, donation and other rules but imposed sanctions only twice, after parties failed to take corrective action.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The end of the year is packed with European Council summits. There’s the one that starts today (and continues on Friday), plus an informal summit in Dublin on Nov. 13 and then the leaders are back in Brussels on Dec. 17 and 18. On top of that, we hear there will be an extra summit in late November. But 2026 won’t top 2020, when leaders met a whopping 13 times (many of which were via video conference because of Covid-19, which is also the reason they met so often).

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked what you would call your memoir. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shout-out.

YOUR EUROPEAN COUNCIL CHEAT SHEET

ON YOUR MARKS: António Costa wanted to focus on the next seven-year budget at this EU leaders’ summit. Instead, leaders are going to talk about ⋯ pretty much everything. “It’s the largest agenda ever since Costa took over,” one senior diplomat said. Here’s your handy guide to the first day of the marathon diplomatic session.

Blaming each other ⋯ Leaders will kick off with talks on energy, with capitals and the Commission expected to point fingers at each other over high prices. Climate rules could take a beating, too.

⋯ then blaming Beijing: Lunch is devoted to “macroeconomic imbalance” — Brussels-speak for China. Ursula von der Leyen will brief leaders on trade talks with Beijing. Expect renewed demands for the Commission to “urgently” sharpen its trade defenses and protect more European industries from Chinese competition, according to POLITICO’s Camille Gijs, who’s been following the prep.

Show me the money: After China, they’ll turn to the elephant in the room — the bloc’s next long-term budget, on which the warring camps are still miles away from an agreement. Spoiler: Don’t expect a breakthrough. “I don’t think we are there yet, nor will we be in the next two days,” one senior EU diplomat said. It’s not looking great for that December deadline .

More mouths to feed: After arguing over how to divide the EU’s money, leaders will discuss letting more countries into the club. Internal reforms to make enlargement possible are on the menu, with Montenegro hoping for a pat on the back and Ukraine hoping its path is not decoupled from that of Moldova.

WATCH LIKE A PRO: There’s plenty more in my guide to the two-day summit here .

DASHBOARD

EU leaders are expected to broach the topic of Europe's major trade imbalance with China over lunch today, after the bloc's trade chief brokered a deal last week to cap the imports of Chinese hybrid cars from 2027. Import numbers have increased sharply — a senior EU official even said the 2026 tally could land above 800,000 cars.

3 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

RUSSIA'S APPS TAKE A HIT: Ukrainian strikes on Russian data centers haven't just disrupted Moscow's military communications — food deliveries, online payments and ride-hailing services have been affected, too .

DON'T TOUCH DEFENSE: As EU capitals prepare to take the ax to the Commission's €2 trillion budget proposal, Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius is warning that cutting military funding would delay Europe's rearmament.

BABIŠ' BRUSSELS HEADACHE: The Commission still considers Czech PM Andrej Babiš' ties to agribusiness giant Agrofert a conflict of interest , even though he put the company in a trust fund, according to a letter obtained by Transparency International Czechia.

Berlin Global Dialogue: Advancing alliances for the new era. From October 20–22, Berlin Global Dialogue unites leaders from business, government, and academia to shape a new economic era. Learn more and watch the livestream here !

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny spells, with a high of 21C.

OKTOBERFEST, ICH LIEBE DICH: After all the hype, your author finally made it to the opening of Brussels Oktoberfest. The verdict? Quite possibly the best party I've attended in 10 years in Brussels.

"It's something in between an Irish wedding and Bilbo Baggins' birthday," a Commission source told me, looking utterly flabbergasted as we bumped into each other in the crowd. "I'm German, but this thing is wild," added a journalist from another news outlet.

Where to start? No beer came in anything smaller than a liter. My memories are a little hazy, but I distinctly remember falling off a bench and getting drenched in beer in front of my partner in crime for the evening, Berlin Playbook's Hans von der Burchard.

The Berlaymont goes Bavarian: Tables were assigned by Commission cabinet, with Ursula von der Leyen's team inexplicably parked by the entrance. It was basically the Berlaymont with beer and lederhosen — and more networking than at your average EU summit.

Spotted? Forget it. For the first time in my Playbook career, I gave up on keeping tabs on the guests. Too many people. Let's just say half the EU bubble was dancing on benches (how much weight can those things take?).

Among the familiar faces I did note: EU trade chief Maroš Šefčovič, sporting a traditional Lebkuchenherz gingerbread heart around his neck ⋯ former Commissioner Günther Oettinger, who happens to celebrate his birthday today ("He's always here, every year," one EU official told me) ⋯ and European

Parliament President Roberta Metsola, who made her entrance alongside a delegation of Bavarian VIPs, briefly looking as if she was the guest of honor. Bavarian premier Markus Söder was a no-show.

One piece of advice for next year: Get. An. Invitation.

SPOTTED ⋯ at POLITICO's European Resilience Summit in Brussels: Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius; Willem van de Voorde, Belgium's permanent representative to NATO; MEPs Kathleen Van Brempt, Diego Solier and Hana Jalloul Muro; former MEP and International Relations Director at Viohalco Maria Spyraki; Aliyyah Ahad, the Bermuda government's Brussels representative; Doris Manu, from the Permanent Representation of Romania to the EU; Ecuadorian diplomat Erika Martillo Naranjo; Rebecca Lambert, from the U.K. Mission to the EU; Armand van de Laar, secretary-director at Amsterdam Metropolitan Region; the European Commission's Michaela Di Bucci; DG FISMA Director-General Paulina Dejmek Hack; Jacek Jastrzębski, chair of the Polish Financial Supervision Authority; Jean-David Malo, acting director for the European Research Area and Innovation at DG Research; Karine Cenci, head of cabinet for the European Investment Fund's chief executive; Alina-Stefania Ujupan, head of cabinet to Commission Executive Vice President Roxana Mînzatu; Steven Everts, director of the European Union Institute for Security Studies; Maria Karagiannidou-Rosiek, head of policy at IOGP Europe ⋯

And more ⋯ J.P. Morgan's Daniel Rudnicki Schlumberger; Tom Howes, DG ENER green transition adviser; Thibaut Kleiner, director for future networks at DG CONNECT; Felix Fernandez-Shaw, director for decarbonization, mobility and raw materials at DG GROW; Linlin Liang, from the China Chamber of Commerce to the EU; Géraldine Ang, the OECD's team lead for clean energy finance and investment mobilization; the Environmental Defense Fund Europe's Léa Pilsner; Nicolas Monsarrat, Accenture Europe's managing director for health and public service; Maxime Bureau, HP's vice president of government affairs for EMEA.

And breathe ⋯ Google's Annette Kroeber-Riel; Alpesh Shah, managing director of the IEEE Standards Association; Holger Weintritt, head of pharmaceuticals product supply at Bayer; McKinsey & Company's Jens Giersberg; MALT CEO Vincent Huguet; Fire Point CEO Iryna Terekh; Appian Capital Advisory's CEO of Critical Minerals Paulo Castellari; Leibniz Centre for European Economic Research President Achim Wambach; Alessandro Gropelli, Connect Europe director-general; former Slovak Defense Minister Martin Sklenár, distinguished fellow in the Future of Security Program at GLOBSEC; and Accenture's Digital Sovereignty Lead for EMEA Mauro Capo.

SPOTTED ⋯ at Netflix and POLITICO's screening of "The Diplomat" in Brussels: European Commission spokesperson Anna-Kaisa Itkonen; Catherine Martens-Preiss, Renew Europe parliamentary spokesperson; EU Ambassador to Mexico Belén Martínez Carbonell; and European Commission cabinet members Luis Planas Herrera, Simonas Šatūnas, Sonia Vila Nuñez and Triinu Volmer; Caitlin Griffith of the U.K. Mission to the EU; Jenny Hayhurst of the U.K. Joint Delegation to NATO; Sara Mathews of the U.S. Mission to the EU; Adrienne Bory of the U.S. Department of State; Rihards Bambals, from Latvia's Permanent Representation to the EU; the European Parliament's Jesús Carmona Núñez; Sabine Henssler of the Motion Picture Association for Europe; McKinsey's Danielle Burr; Netflix's Rut Rey and Sergio Vinay; and POLITICO's Carrie Budoff Brown, Katie Palisoul, Matthew Woelfel and Gavin Sundwall.

SPOTTED ⋯ at the Brussels launch of Romania's business association Concordia at the Residence Palace: Dan □ucu, president of the Concordia Employers' Confederation; Radu Burnete, Romanian presidential adviser; Iulia Matei, Romanian ambassador to the EU; BusinessEurope's Director-General Markus J. Beyrer; Victor Negrescu, vice president of the European Parliament; Alina Ujupan, head of

cabinet of Executive Vice President Roxana Mînzatu; MEP Nicu □tefănu□ă, the Greens' co-chair; Adelina Dabu, director of EU and international affairs at Concordia; and POLITICO's Mari Eccles and Vlad Hosu.

NIGHT AT THE MUSEUM: Museum Night Fever is back in Brussels on Saturday. For one night only, dozens of museums and galleries will open their doors, from Bozar to the Sewer Museum (yes, that's a thing). There'll be live music, workshops, light installations and an after-party at C12. Tickets and full program .

EU LAUGHS: There are just a few days left before the latest edition of EU comedy "The Schuman Show," on Oct. 21, 22 and 23. Tickets here .

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz wanted to focus on China and the EU budget at the Council summit today, but the worsening crisis in Ukraine is threatening to take over the agenda.

Paris: Bruno Retailleau rebuffed an invitation from presidential rival Edouard Philippe to hold private talks and wants a public debate instead — but Philippe's aides quickly shot that down.

Madrid: Polls point to a PP-Vox majority in next month's election, but one former Sánchez adviser says the Socialists could still win the most seats if Vox takes votes from the PP in smaller constituencies.

London: Chancellor John Healey is facing a day of scrutiny over his upcoming budget, amid reports the government will raise taxes and cut spending rather than increase borrowing.

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AGENDA

— The European Council begins in Brussels, chaired by Council President António Costa. It will be attended by Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Parliament President Roberta Metsola, along with the leaders of the 27 EU member states. Leaders will discuss competitiveness and energy prices, the 2028–2034 EU budget, support for Ukraine, security and defense, migration, enlargement and the Middle East.

Key timings: Arrivals and doorsteps from 8:30 a.m. ⋯ exchange of views with Metsola at 10 a.m. ⋯ press conference with Metsola around 10:30 a.m. (watch live) ⋯ working lunch at 1 p.m. ⋯ press conference with Costa and von der Leyen at 7:30 p.m. (watch live) ⋯ working dinner at 8 p.m.

— EPP leaders meet before the summit at 7:30 a.m., with participants including von der Leyen and Metsola.

— EU Education Ministers hold an informal meeting in Dublin, hosted by Irish ministers Hildegarde Naughton and James Lawless. Executive Vice President Roxana Mînzatu will also participate. Press conference at 5:30 p.m. Watch live .

— Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis attends the G7 and G20 finance ministers meetings in Bangkok, Thailand.

— International Partnerships Commissioner Jozef Síkela attends the 114th meeting of the Development Committee in Bangkok and meets the International Finance Corporation's Managing Director Makhtar Diop, Thailand's Finance Minister Ekniti Nitithanprapas, Rwanda's Finance Minister Yusuf Murangwa, and Nigeria's Finance Minister Taiwo Oyedele.

— Democracy Commissioner Michael McGrath gives the opening address at the AI in Science Summit in Dublin.

— Crisis Management Commissioner Hadja Lahbib and Internal Affairs Commissioner Magnus Brunner meet Ukraine's Social Policy Minister Denys Uliutin.

— Lahbib delivers the opening remarks on the first day of the International Conference on the Protection of Humanitarian Aid Workers in Brussels.

— Climate Commissioner Wopke Hoekstra hosts an implementation dialogue on the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM).

BIRTHDAYS

Former European Commissioner Günther Oettinger; French presidential candidate and MEP Raphaël Glucksmann; MEPs Alicia Homs Ginel and Yana Toom; former MEPs Danilo Oscar Lancini, Karen Melchior, Belinda de Lucy, Wajid Khan and Soraya Post; POLITICO alum Lukas Kotkamp; Wine&Politics' Gilhean Slater; Fabio Marchetti from Generali; Jan Yves Remy from the Shridath Ramphal Centre for International Trade Law, Policy and Services.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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